CHAPTER 10

FUTURE OF TTP AND TERRORISM

SPLINTERING OF TTP: THE BEGINNING OF TTP'S END?

In 2009–12, the government of Pakistan and some analysts repeatedly predicted the decline and ultimate death of TTP. The first wave of this misplaced optimism came after Baitullah Mehsud's death in 2009. It was generally felt that the death of charismatic Baitullah would result in the downfall of TTP. It amounted to underestimating TTP's resilience and capacity to continue destruction. Conversely, it bounced back with an increasingly violent campaign of attacks across Pakistan in 2009 and 2010.

After Baitullah's death, there was a brief tiff over the issue of leadership. However, Hakimullah Mehsud prevailed and took over the command of the organisation. Initially, he ran TTP effectively and resorted to more brutal and effective actions in FATA and in urban centres as far as Punjab. This effectiveness did not last long. Two drone attacks on Hakimullah injured him and forced him to go underground. It weakened his position, and his grip over the organisation slackened. Consequently, power struggles ensued within it. It caused the splintering of TTP. Some militant sources were of the view that power struggles between rival militant commanders, both for overall control of the TTP and regional leadership, fractured the coordinated command structure created by the charismatic TTP chief Baitullah Mehsud. By 2011, the TTP had not remained a monolithic organisation. It had